wondering whether people see you as young, as a woman, or as the founder's daughter. You have to focus on becoming someone whose contribution is difficult to ignore," she says.

Starting with a single department, she worked her way through the Bengaluru-headquartered organisation, understanding it from the ground up. She rates the move from finance to broader operational and business leadership as the most significant one. Following the separation of Aster's India and GCC business, she now heads the GCC entity, overseeing operations across the Middle Eastern region, which include 15 hospitals, 126 clinics, and 338 pharmacies. The company recently announced an investment of AED 1 billion (about ₹2,500 crore). It is also expanding its presence to Saudi Arabia.

BUILDING CREDIBILITY, TRUST

Irrespective of the industry, most women leaders have had to fight a bit harder than their male counterparts to establish their credibility.

Part of the problem often is that men don't know how to deal with women in positions of power or senior positions, says Vanitha Datla, Vice Chairperson & Managing Director at Elico Healthcare Services, whose PhD research was on 'Navigating Family Business: An Exploratory Study on Women's Roles and Contributions in Indian Family Enterprises.'

"The new generation of women leaders are highly educated, often abroad, and have worked outside the family business, which helps establish their credentials to some extent," she says. In her research, Datla found that families by and large were always supportive of the women's decision to enter the family enterprise. The resistance came from non-family members who often struggle to take orders from a woman, she says.

When Vinita Gupta joined Lupin, women were sorely under-represented in the pharmaceutical industry.

"YOU CAN'T SPEND TOO MUCH ENERGY WONDERING WHETHER PEOPLE SEE YOU AS YOUNG, AS A WOMAN, OR AS THE FOUNDER'S DAUGHTER. YOU HAVE TO FOCUS ON BECOMING SOMEONE WHOSE CONTRIBUTION IS DIFFICULT TO IGNORE"

ALISHA MOOPEN
MD AND GROUP CEO, ASTER DM HEALTHCARE

- **Responsible for operations across the Middle East, including 15 hospitals, 126 clinics, and 338 pharmacies.**
- **Spearheading expansion into new markets like Saudi Arabia**
- **Leading the use of advanced technology in healthcare, using AI and precision medicine to improve healthcare delivery and patient outcomes**
- **Launched the Women in Leadership programme at Aster DM Healthcare**

